



HOW TO OVERCOME A TRAGEDY

Nehemiah 1:1-2 :8 Nehemiah 1:1-8

I am Nehemiah son of Hacaliah, and in this book I tell what I have done.

1 During the month of Chislev in the twentieth year that Artaxerxes ruled Persia, I was in his fortress city of Susa, 2 when my brother Hanani came with some men from Judah. So I asked them about the Jews who had escaped from being captives in Babylonia. I also asked them about the city of Jerusalem.

3 They told me, “Those captives who have come back are having all kinds of troubles. They are terribly disgraced, Jerusalem’s walls are broken down, and its gates have been burned.”

4 When I heard this, I sat down and cried. Then for several days, I mourned; I went without eating to show my sorrow, and I prayed:

5 LORD God of heaven, you are great and fearsome. And you faithfully keep your promises to everyone who loves you and obeys your commands. 6 I am your servant, so please have mercy on me and answer the prayer that I make day and night for these people of Israel who serve you. I, my family, and the rest of your people have sinned 7 by choosing to disobey you and the laws and teachings you gave to your servant Moses.

8 Please remember the promise you made to Moses. You told him that if we were unfaithful, you would scatter us among foreign nations. ¹

Intro: When tragedy strikes, some react by getting bitter, blaming God, withdrawing, and never working through a constructive reaction. Nehemiah shows us how to react positively and constructively to tragedy. His tragedy was that his homeland had been devastated, the wall of Jerusalem had been broken down. He was far away from home, and the news hit him hard. How he reacted made all the difference.

When reacting to tragedy:

I. Take time to MOURN (1:4)

- A. It is okay to cry.
- B. We should not deny our true feelings of grief.
- C. It is not a sign of strength to deny our grief.
- D. A person’s mental, emotional, and physical

¹*The Contemporary English [computer file], electronic ed., Logos Library System, (Nashville: Thomas Nelson) 1997, c1995 by the American Bible Society.*

health demands that we take time to mourn when necessary.

II. Take time to MEDITATE (1:4b--11)

- A. Meditation involves Confession
- B. Meditation involves Petition
- C. Meditation involves Intercession
- D. Meditation involves Introspection

III. THEN MOVE TO ACTION (1:11B--2:8)

- A. Avoid getting "stuck" in grief process.
- B. Constructively DO what you can about the situation, as God leads, in His timing.
- C. Action is grief's best therapy.
(example: If cancer is your tragedy, begin or get active in helping other cancer patients)
- D. God will provide the resources for recuperation from tragedy.

Conclusion:

To face tragedy constructively, Nehemiah offers a very healthy example. God blesses every effort to react constructively to the tragedies of life. Have you taken time to mourn, meditate, and then move to action?